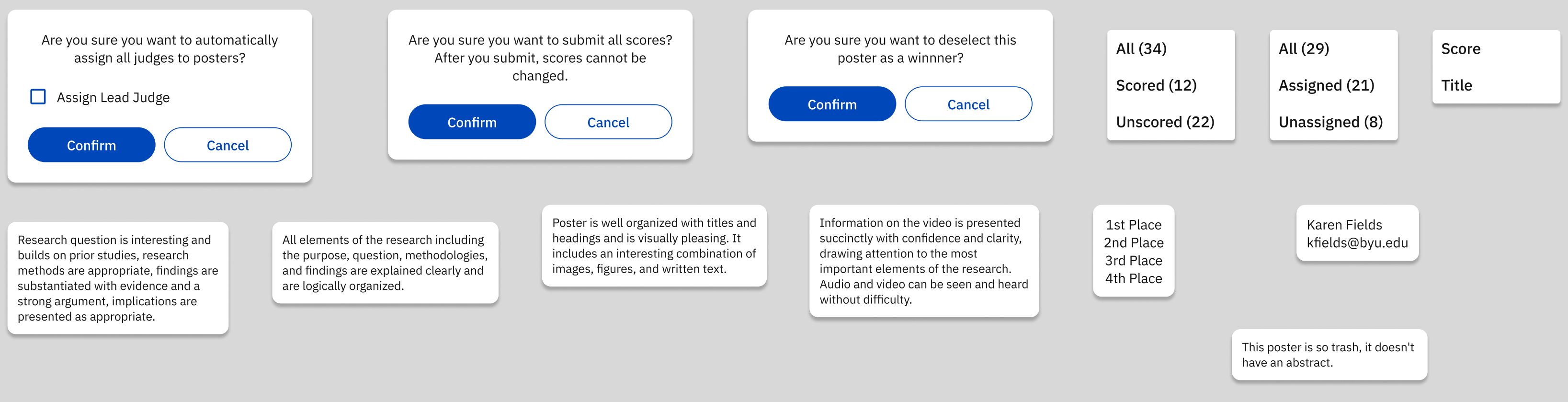


Are you sure you want to automatically assign all judges to posters?

☐ Assign Lead Judge

Are you sure you want to submit all scores? After you submit, scores cannot be changed.

Are you sure you want to deselect this poster as a winnner?

All (34)
Scored (12)
Unscored (22)

All (29)
Assigned (21)
Unassigned (8)

Score
Title

Research question is interesting and builds on prior studies, research methods are appropriate, findings are substantiated with evidence and a strong argument, implications are presented as appropriate.

All elements of the research including the purpose, question, methodologies, and findings are explained clearly and are logically organized.

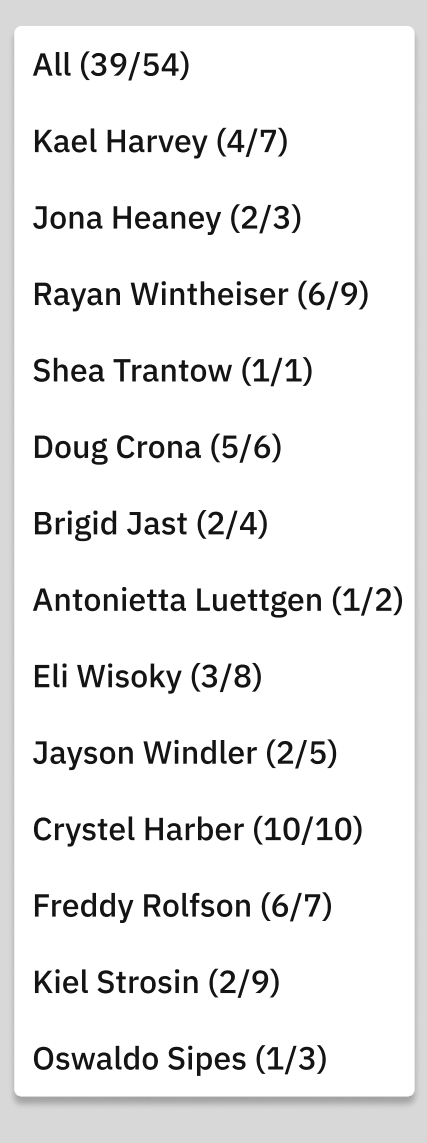
Poster is well organized with titles and headings and is visually pleasing. It includes an interesting combination of images, figures, and written text.

Information on the video is presented succinctly with confidence and clarity, drawing attention to the most important elements of the research. Audio and video can be seen and heard without difficulty.

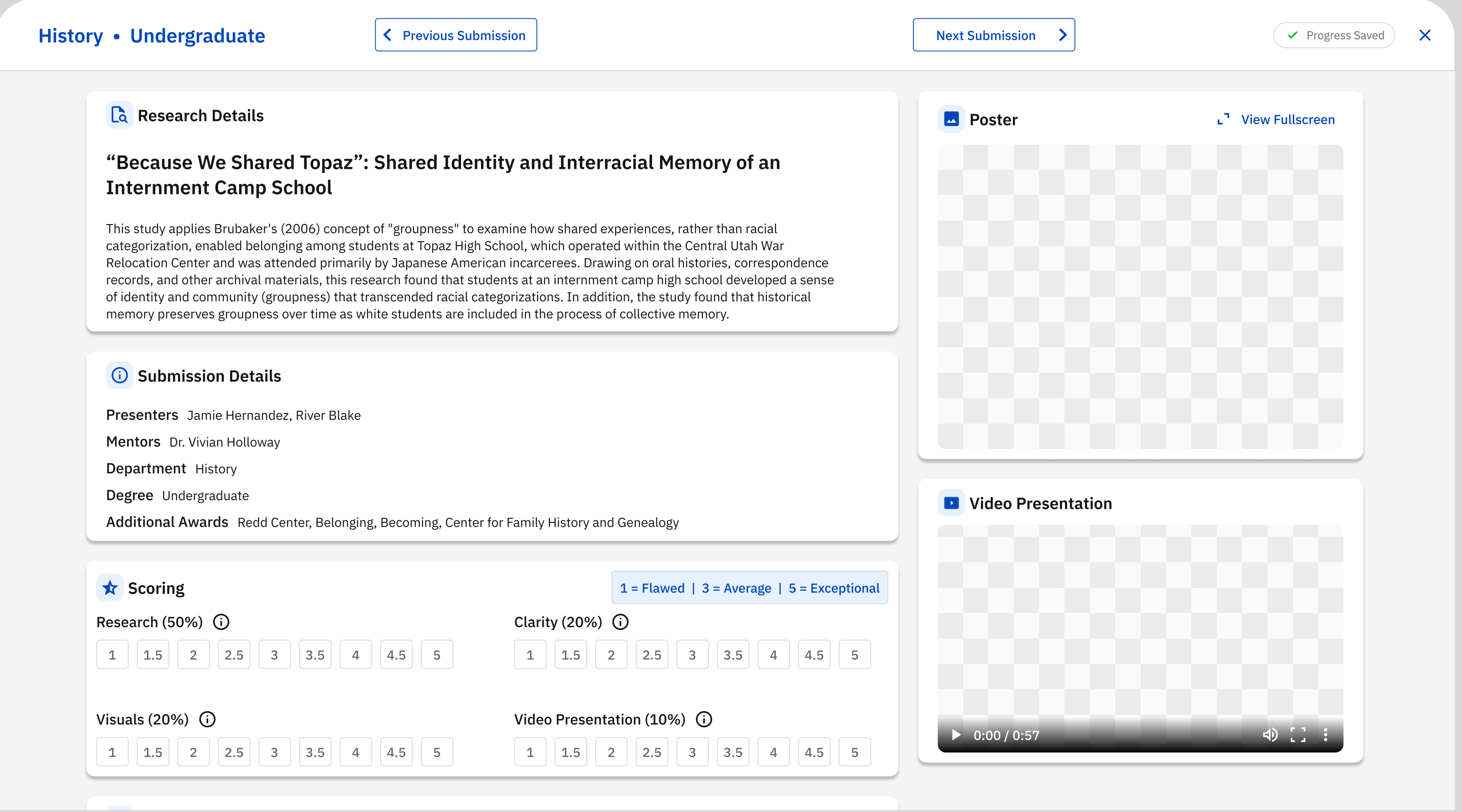
1st Place
2nd Place
3rd Place
4th Place

Karen Fields
kfields@byu.edu

This poster is so trash, it doesn't have an abstract.



All (39/54)
Kael Harvey (4/7)
Jona Heaney (2/3)
Rayan Wintheiser (6/9)
Shea Trantow (1/1)
Doug Crona (5/6)
Brigid Jast (2/4)
Antonietta Luettgen (1/2)
Eli Wisoky (3/8)
Jayson Windler (2/5)
Crystel Harber (10/10)
Freddy Rolfson (6/7)
Kiel Strosin (2/9)
Oswaldo Sipes (1/3)



History • Undergraduate

Research Details

"Because We Shared Topaz": Shared Identity and Interracial Memory of an Internment Camp School

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Mentors Dr. Vivian Holloway
Department History
Degree Undergraduate
Additional Awards Redd Center, Belonging, Becoming, Center for Family History and Genealogy

Scoring

1 = Flawed | 3 = Average | 5 = Exceptional

Research (50%)
1 1.5 2 2.5 3 3.5 4 4.5 5

Clarity (20%)
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Visuals (20%)
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Video Presentation (10%)
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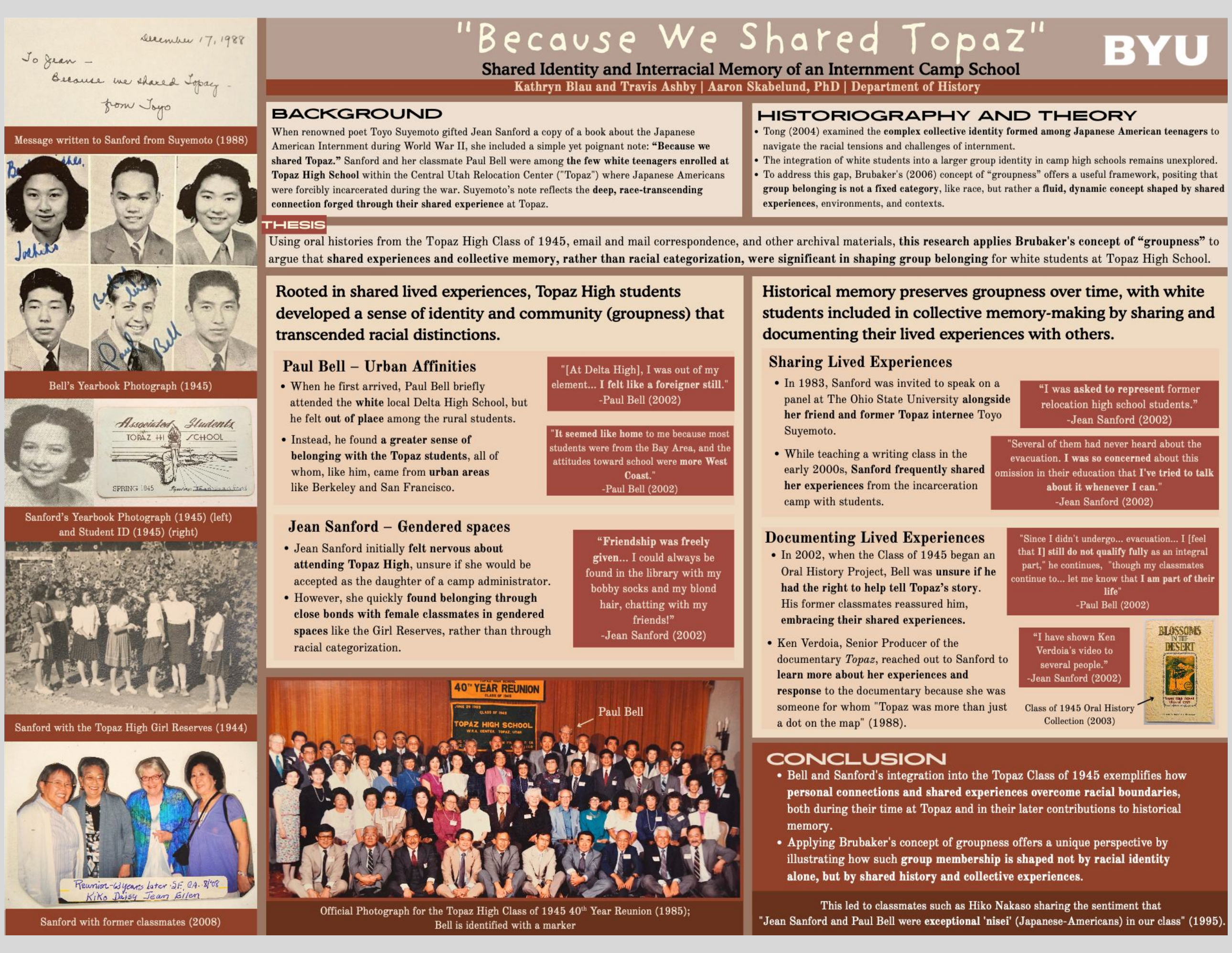
Poster

Video Presentation



"Because We Shared Topaz"

Shared Identity and Interracial Memory of an Internment Camp School

Kathryn Blau and Travis Ashby | Aaron Skabelund, PhD | Department of History

December 17, 1988
To Jean –
Because we shared Topaz –
from Toyo

Message written to Sanford from Suyemoto (1988)

Bell's Yearbook Photograph (1945)

Sanford's Yearbook Photograph (1945) (left) and Student ID (1945) (right)

Sanford with the Topaz High Girl Reserves (1944)

Reunion – 63 years later SF, CA. 8/08
Kiko Daisy Jean Ellen

Sanford with former classmates (2008)

BACKGROUND

When renowned poet Toyo Suyemoto gifted Jean Sanford a copy of a book about the Japanese American Internment during World War II, she included a simple yet poignant note: **"Because we shared Topaz."** Sanford and her classmate Paul Bell were among **the few white teenagers enrolled at Topaz High School** within the Central Utah Relocation Center ("Topaz") where Japanese Americans were forcibly incarcerated during the war. Suyemoto's note reflects the **deep, race-transcending connection forged through their shared experience** at Topaz.

HISTORIOGRAPHY AND THEORY

- Tong (2004) examined the **complex collective identity formed among Japanese American teenagers** to navigate the racial tensions and challenges of internment.
- The integration of white students into a larger group identity in camp high schools remains unexplored.
- To address this gap, Brubaker's (2006) concept of "groupness" offers a useful framework, positing that **group belonging is not a fixed category**, like race, but rather a **fluid, dynamic concept shaped by shared experiences**, environments, and contexts.

THESIS

Using oral histories from the Topaz High Class of 1945, email and mail correspondence, and other archival materials, **this research applies Brubaker's concept of "groupness"** to argue that **shared experiences and collective memory, rather than racial categorization, were significant in shaping group belonging** for white students at Topaz High School.

Rooted in shared lived experiences, Topaz High students developed a sense of identity and community (groupness) that transcended racial distinctions.

Paul Bell – Urban Affinities

- When he first arrived, Paul Bell briefly attended the **white** local Delta High School, but he felt **out of place** among the rural students.
- Instead, he found **a greater sense of belonging with the Topaz students**, all of whom, like him, came from **urban areas** like Berkeley and San Francisco.

"[At Delta High], I was out of my element… **I felt like a foreigner still.**"
-Paul Bell (2002)

"**It seemed like home** to me because most students were from the Bay Area, and the attitudes toward school were **more West Coast.**"
-Paul Bell (2002)

Jean Sanford – Gendered spaces

- Jean Sanford initially **felt nervous about attending Topaz High**, unsure if she would be accepted as the daughter of a camp administrator.
- However, she quickly **found belonging through close bonds with female classmates in gendered spaces** like the Girl Reserves, rather than through racial categorization.

"**Friendship was freely given…** I could always be found in the library with my bobby socks and my blond hair, chatting with my friends!"
-Jean Sanford (2002)

Official Photograph for the Topaz High Class of 1945 40th Year Reunion (1985); Bell is identified with a marker

Historical memory preserves groupness over time, with white students included in collective memory-making by sharing and documenting their lived experiences with others.

Sharing Lived Experiences

- In 1983, Sanford was invited to speak on a panel at The Ohio State University **alongside her friend and former Topaz internee** Toyo Suyemoto.
- While teaching a writing class in the early 2000s, **Sanford frequently shared her experiences** from the incarceration camp with students.

"I was **asked to represent** former relocation high school students."
-Jean Sanford (2002)

"Several of them had never heard about the evacuation. **I was so concerned** about this omission in their education that **I've tried to talk about it whenever I can.**"
-Jean Sanford (2002)

Documenting Lived Experiences

- In 2002, when the Class of 1945 began an Oral History Project, Bell was **unsure if he had the right to help tell Topaz's story.** His former classmates reassured him, **embracing their shared experiences.**
- Ken Verdoia, Senior Producer of the documentary *Topaz*, reached out to Sanford to **learn more about her experiences and response** to the documentary because she was someone for whom "Topaz was more than just a dot on the map" (1988).

"Since I didn't undergo… evacuation… I [feel that I] **still do not qualify fully** as an integral part," he continues, "though my classmates continue to… let me know that **I am part of their life**"
-Paul Bell (2002)

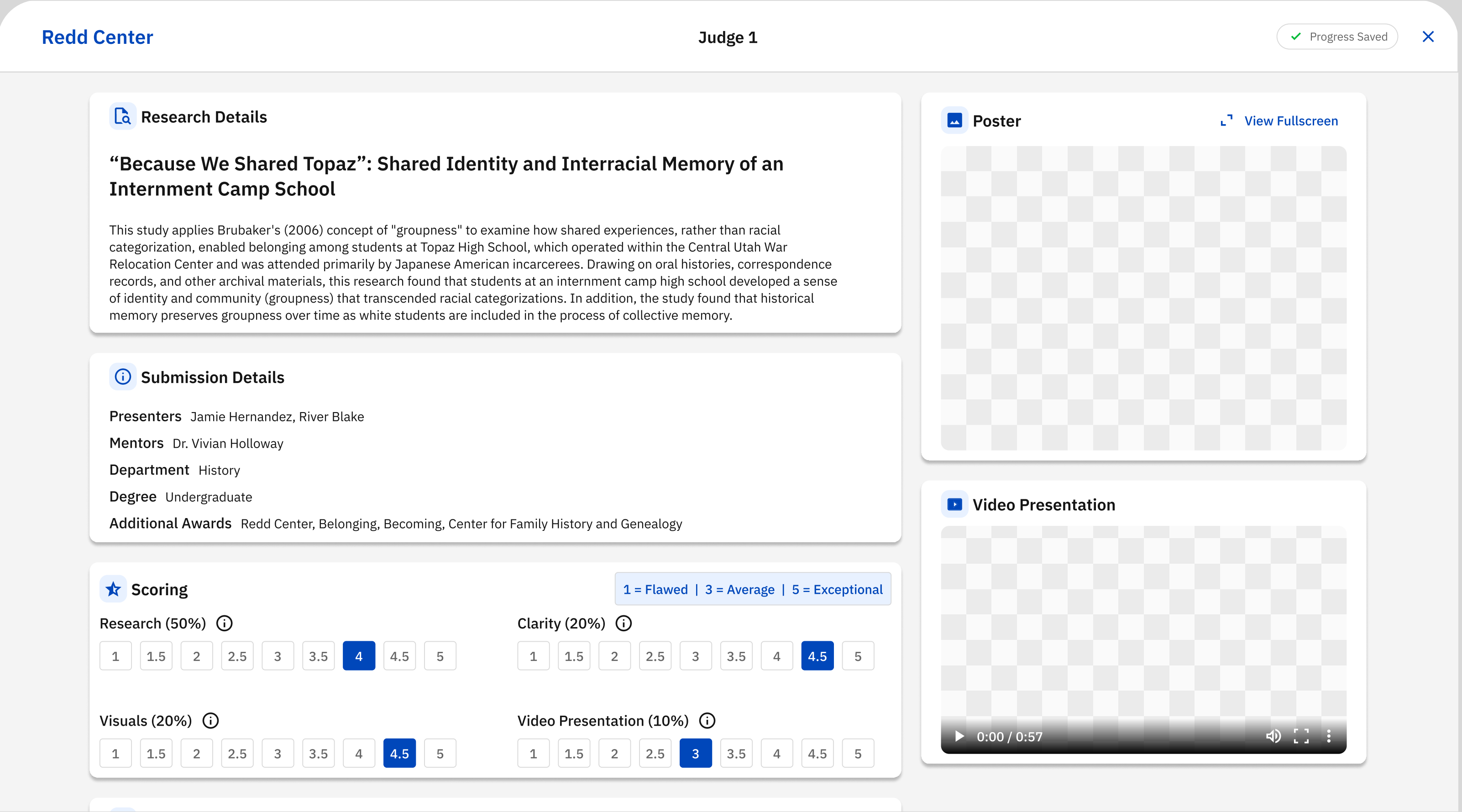
"I have shown Ken Verdoia's video to several people."
-Jean Sanford (2002)

Class of 1945 Oral History Collection (2003)

CONCLUSION

- Bell and Sanford's integration into the Topaz Class of 1945 exemplifies how **personal connections and shared experiences overcome racial boundaries,** both during their time at Topaz and in their later contributions to historical memory.
- Applying Brubaker's concept of groupness offers a unique perspective by illustrating how such **group membership is shaped not by racial identity alone, but by shared history and collective experiences.**

This led to classmates such as Hiko Nakaso sharing the sentiment that "Jean Sanford and Paul Bell were **exceptional 'nisei'** (Japanese-Americans) in our class" (1995).



Redd Center

Judge 1

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Poster

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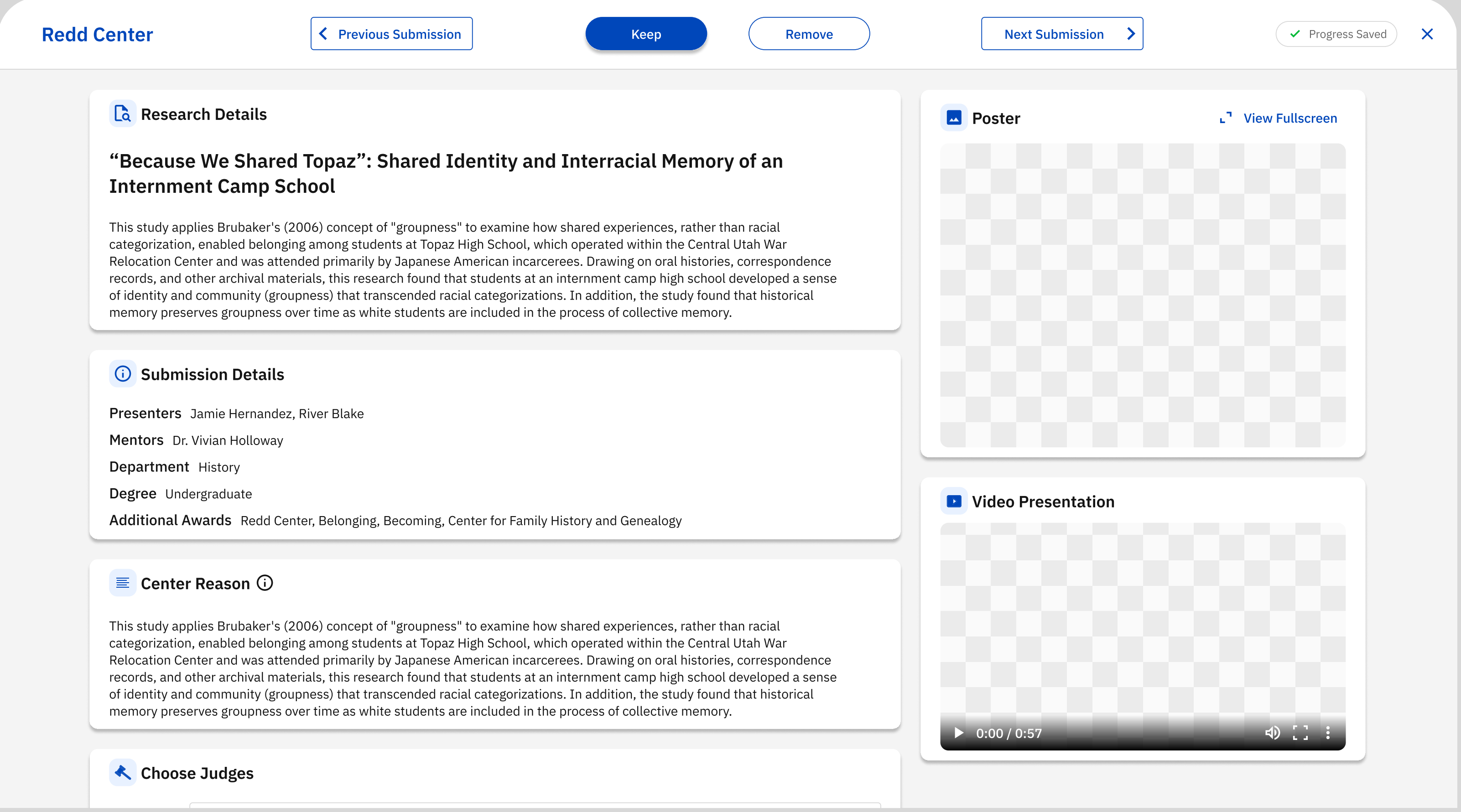

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Choose Judges

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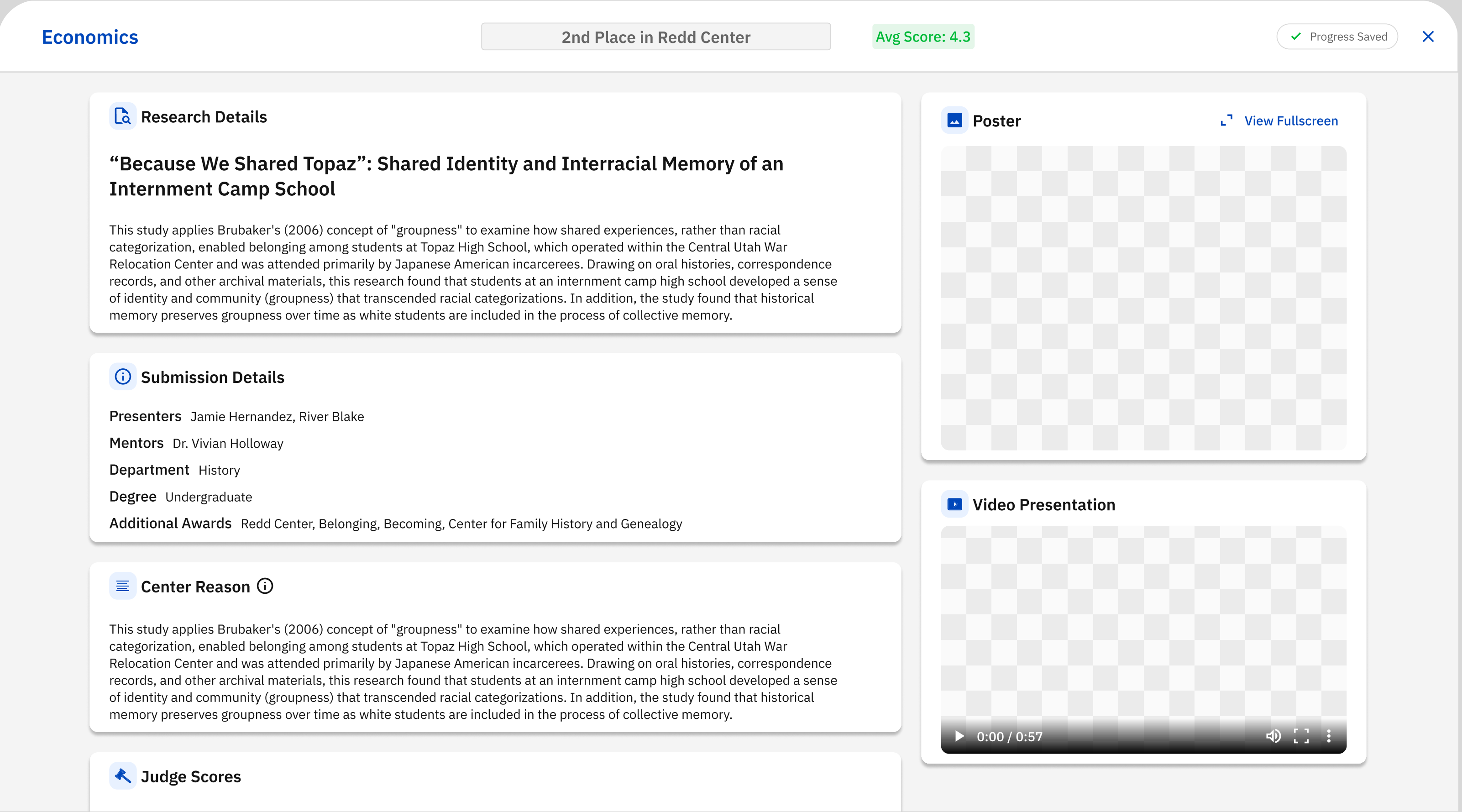

Economics

2nd Place in Redd Center

Avg Score: 4.3

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Judge Scores

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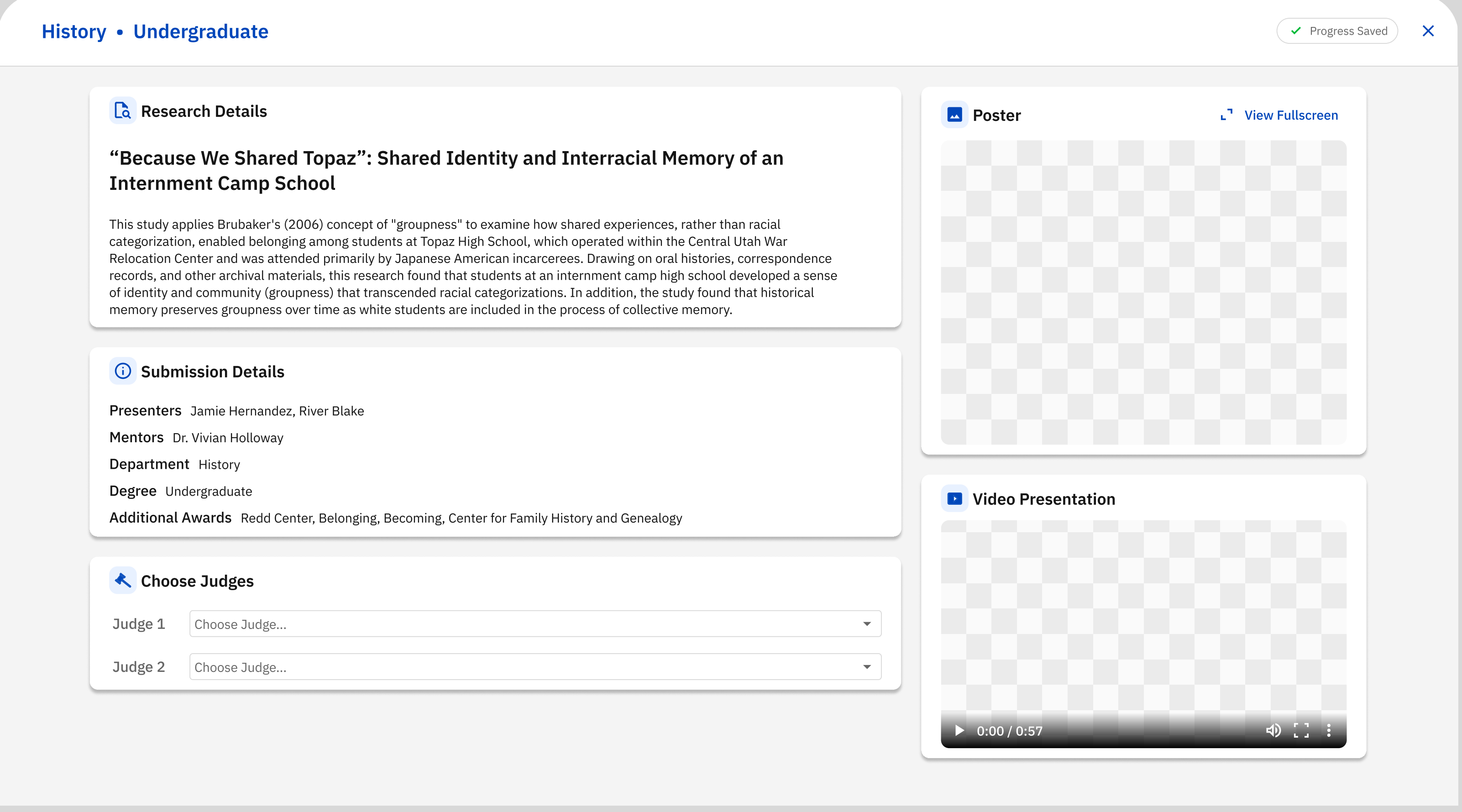

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Judge 1: Choose Judge…
Judge 2: Choose Judge…

Poster

Video Presentation